

REGENCY SOCIETY

In the early 1800s Regency Britain changed from a rural society to an urban, trading one, and London became an important centre. A "social season" evolved during the 17th and 18th centuries where the better off divided their year between the high life of London (also Edinburgh and Dublin) and hunting seasons at country residences. Provincial towns and cities boasted Assembly Rooms and theatres for the proliferating middle classes. Social rounds provided chances for young people to parade their looks and fashionable clothes in order to make good marriages.

In this fashionable evening gathering in Bristol in 1817, the young women favour a relatively simple look: a pale empire-line gown with a low, wide neckline, short puffed sleeves, gloves, fan, and modest floral hair ornaments. Frilled and decorated hems and shorter dress lengths had recently gained currency, and diaphanous fabrics such as muslin and gauze, including satin gowns with net overlays, were popular. Maturer and married ladies dressed in stronger colours with fancy headwear.

The gentlemen wear long-skirted frock coats, tall, upright collars, and cravat-style neck cloths. Transitions in menswear are apparent – the man on the right wears black knee-breeches and silk stockings, while the man in the centre with a lady on each arm sports loosely cut trousers.

“

What gown and what head-dress she should wear...became her chief concern...She lay awake ten minutes on Wednesday night debating between her spotted and her tamboured muslin, and nothing but the shortness of time prevented her buying a new one for the evening.

JANE AUSTEN, *NORTHANGER ABBEY*, 1817

”

◀ THE CLOAKROOM, CLIFTON ASSEMBLY ROOMS, 1817

Men and women prepared carefully for a social event in Regency England. Artist Rolinda Sharples shows them in the cloakroom of the Assembly Rooms in Clifton, a fashionable area of Bristol.

